

Out of SIGHT

This novel captures the post-riot life without falling into the trap of misery tourism



FUGITIVE HISTORIES
by GITHA HARIHARAN
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| By Geeta Doctor |

The sound of a sewing machine resonates through the waking life of Yasmin. She is a young girl, a fugitive from the history of the subcontinent trapped in the interstices of recent events that Githa Hariharan stitches together as relentlessly as Ammi, Yasmin's mother, pieces together the cut-rate skirts in their one-room tenement. One has only to mention the name of the city to know where exactly all this leads. Ahmedabad.

It's a measure of Hariharan's tenacity as a writer that even while moving from the very same cut-rate story of communal hate and horror that has been played so many times in the media by social activists and documentary filmmakers, she is able to colour it with her own brand of fierce integrity that we are able to look at it again. As in many of Hariharan's characteristic insights, we are led to wonder: is it the machine that is sewing the skirt, or the skirt that is driving the machine faster and faster into a vortex where the daily lives of individuals and those of history appear to blur and seep through time and memory till they appear to become all of a piece. Or as she describes Ammi working at her piece rate skirts: "She tacks one hour to another, sews one long day on to one long night, and stitches the days and weeks and months together. By the time she has finished all the skirts she has to stitch, her life will be over, and it will be time to go to paradise, to see Akbar again." Akbar is her son, the missing person, presumed dead.

Hariharan's novel documents the lives of

these missing persons. She has always been better at the short story form. Her fondness for the minutiae of daily life, particularly the hidden moles, the magnified bodily creases, papery skins, erasures of marks left by illness, pregnancy or errant passion, but most particularly, what one can only describe as a fastidious Brahminical nose for smells that borders on distaste are what give her prose an exquisite awareness. It's out of her very unease that she alerts us to these subliminal differences that make up our lives in this subcontinent of suppressed desires—the hungry ghosts that both divide and unite us into what we might call our Indian-ness.

The novelist may just as well as presented it as her reading of the Gujarat carnage and pogroms that followed it. She even alerts us, through the eyes of her protagonist Sara, who is somewhat tritely, it has to be said, doing research for a film on the subject that there is an element of misery tourism going on here.

Apart from being the main observer through which the events unfold, part of the novel traces Sara's history. Her mother Mala is a Tam-brahm and Hariharan explores what for her is familiar territory of the austere Brahminical way of life in describing Mala's ancestral home and partially crazed grandmother. Her father, Asad is a north

Indian Muslim, an artist, who has just died, leaving a trunk-full of drawings for Mala to discover.

She opens them a bit like Pandora and her famous box containing all the miseries that will afflict mankind, in this case the country's scabs and sores that have accumulated in the history of our recent past. Is there still hope left for us, just when we despair of it? Hariharan is still too full of her own sense of destiny to let the box close upon her secrets without releasing the fragmented but still luminous butterfly of hope. ■



SAURABH SINGH